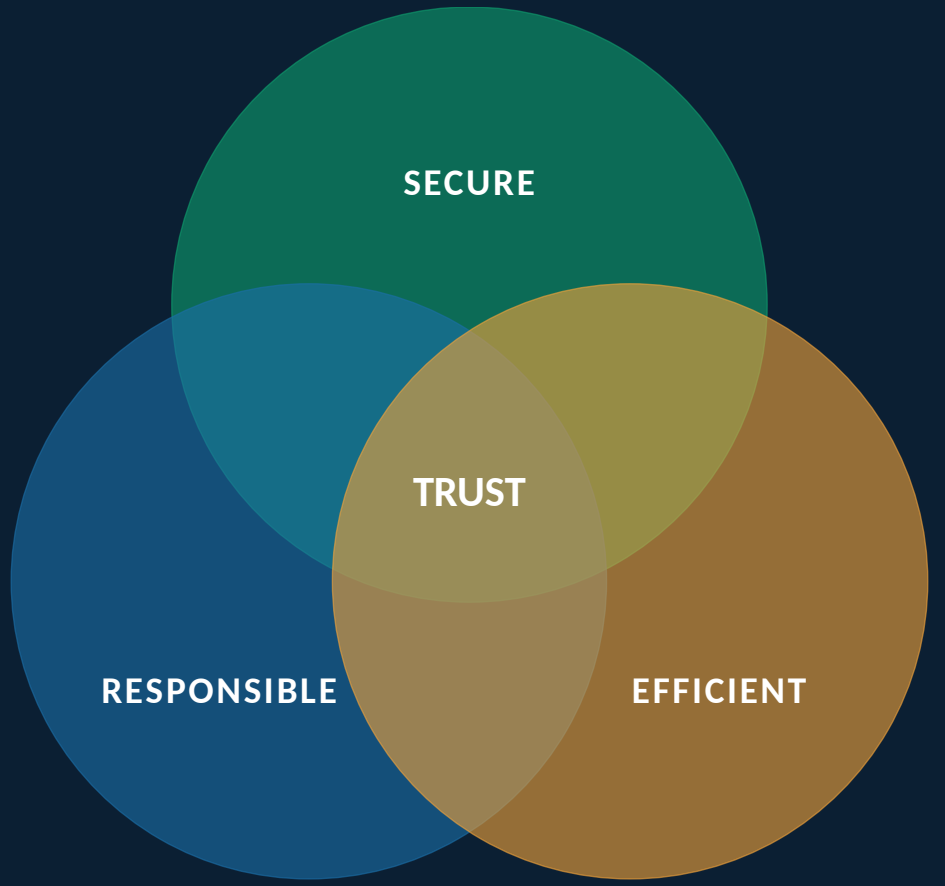
IT SUMMIT 2027

Inter-University Hackathon

Event plan for a student hackathon at the Limerick IT Summit 2027



Mohit Behl · **Volunteer Coordinator**

November 2026 · Draft for discussion

The plan at a glance

A proven hackathon format, updated for Irish universities and built into the Limerick IT Summit.

3

Rounds

Online idea round, online build sprint, then an on-site finale

12

Challenge domains

11 kept from the reference event and re-scoped for Ireland, plus 1 new

24 h

Grand Finale

Sat 27 – Sun 28 Feb 2027, the weekend before the summit (assumed)

25–30

Finalist teams

About 100 to 120 students at the finale

2–4

Students per team

Aged 18+, any institution in Ireland; mixed teams welcome

1

Shared baseline

The Trust Triad: secure, responsible, efficient

Built for the Limerick IT Summit

A free, non-profit tech summit for SMEs. The hackathon becomes its student strand.

What we know about the summit

- Free, non-profit event for SME owners and technology professionals
- 2025: Thursday 6 March · 2026: Thursday 26 February
- Dell Technologies campus, Raheen; over 450 places in 2026
- 2026 theme: “Your AI Toolkit”
- 2027 date not yet announced

What it means for the hackathon

- SME Challenge Bank: real problems from local businesses
- Grand Finale on the weekend before the summit
- Winners demo and pitch at the summit; SME Choice award
- Mid-West institutions first, then national outreach
- Free entry, in-kind support, one volunteer team

Source: public coverage of the 2025 and 2026 editions (report section 2). The summit website could not be opened when this deck was prepared.

Keep what worked, fix what didn't

The reference event gives us a tested backbone. We fix the gaps we found in its documents.



Keep from the reference event

- Short, fixed idea deck for Round 1
- Five judging criteria at 20% each
- Start-up, industry and academic jury
- T-60 to T+30 planning checklists
- 10–15% contingency and a waitlist for no-shows
- Welfare: women volunteers at night, a quiet room



Fix or update

- Slide limit given as both 5 and 5–7 → one limit of 6
- “Quantity of code” → quality and a working demo
- Deadline an hour before hacking ends → one code freeze
- Dates “to be announced” → every date set at launch
- IP shared with the host → teams keep their IP
- India-specific domains, no AI or security rules → Irish/EU scope and the Trust Triad

Why these themes matter now

Every domain responds to something that changed in 2024–26.

AI is regulated

EU AI Act transparency duties apply from August 2026; high-risk rules from December 2027.

Attacks hit suppliers

Ransomware on a check-in system supplier disrupted Dublin Airport in September 2025.

Clouds fail too

A major AWS outage in October 2025 was traced to a race condition in DNS automation.

Computing costs energy

Data centres used 22% of Ireland's metered electricity in 2024 (CSO).

Accessibility is law

The European Accessibility Act has applied in Ireland since 28 June 2025.

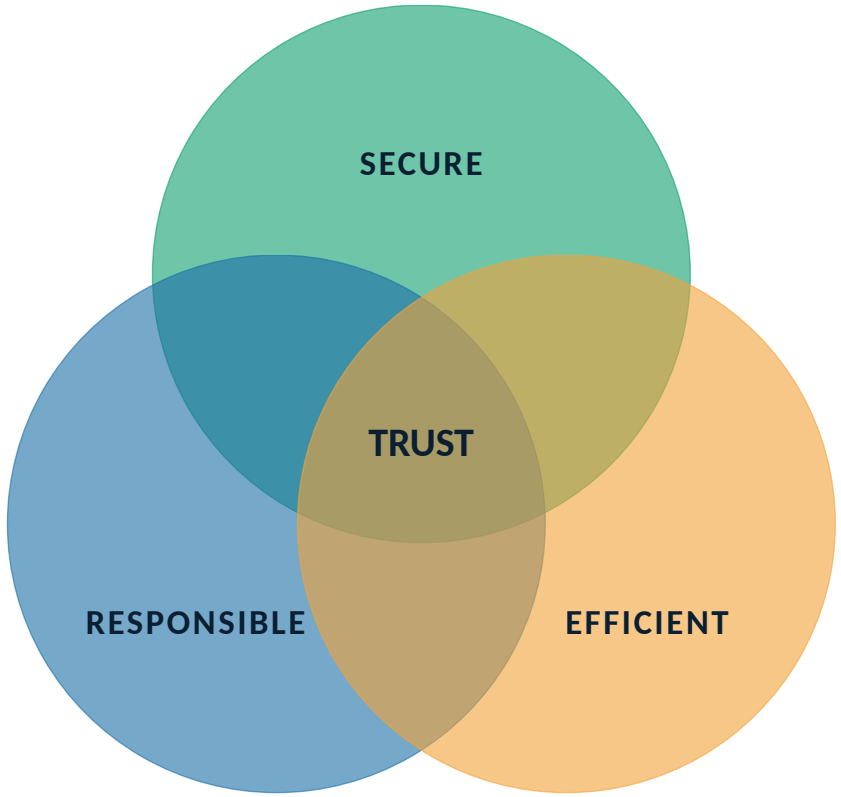
Cyber law tightens

EU Cyber Resilience Act reporting began September 2026; Ireland has yet to transpose NIS2.

Sources: report Appendix C, checked 4 November 2026. Regulatory dates should be re-checked before participant materials are published.

The Trust Triad: one baseline for all

Not a separate track: every project in every domain shows these three qualities.



Secure

No secrets in repositories, authentication for personal data, and the top three threats mitigated

Responsible

Lawful, licensed data; minimal personal data; AI use disclosed; WCAG 2.2 accessibility basics

Efficient

Right-sized models and infrastructure, survives one component failing, optional energy estimate

Evidence: a one-page Trust Card per team · 10% of the finale score · three special awards

Challenge domains 1–6

The reference event's domains, kept and re-scoped for Ireland and the EU.

DOMAIN 1

Applied and Trustworthy AI

Assistants that cite their sources; AI agents with guardrails for business workflows

DOMAIN 2

Agritech and Food Safety

Low-cost soil sensors, farm-to-fork traceability, less food waste on campus

DOMAIN 3

Sustainability and Green Software

Carbon-aware job scheduling; home and campus energy insights

DOMAIN 4

Digital Public Services and Identity

Plain-language public-service guides; verifiable student credentials

DOMAIN 5

Digital Health and Wellbeing

A FHIR referral prototype using synthetic data; wellbeing signposting

DOMAIN 6

Cybersecurity, Privacy and AI Security

Phishing and deepfake detection, prompt-injection defences, post-quantum readiness

Challenge domains 7–12

Domain 12 is new: optimisation and resilience, after the 2024–25 outages.

DOMAIN 7

Smart Mobility and Logistics

Transport reliability from NTA real-time feeds; last-mile route optimisation

DOMAIN 8

EdTech and Skills

A study coach that respects academic integrity; skills-gap mapping

DOMAIN 9

SME Digitalisation and Commerce

An accessibility checker for small online shops; a cyber-hygiene assistant

DOMAIN 10

Accessibility and Inclusive Tech

Tools for Irish Sign Language users; accessible campus navigation

DOMAIN 11

Open Domain (Student Innovation)

Any student idea, with the Trust Triad still applying

DOMAIN 12

NEW

Optimisation, Cloud and Resilient Systems

A cloud cost-and-carbon optimiser, chaos testing, timetable optimisation

Three rounds, rising commitment

Round 2 tests feasibility before anyone travels, which cuts no-shows at the finale.

1 Idea submission

Online · 11 – 29 Jan

- 6-slide idea deck (template supplied)
- Five criteria at 20% each
- Two screening judges per deck

→ Up to 50 teams shortlisted

2 Mentored build sprint

Online · 8 – 15 Feb

- 20-minute mentor session (plus an SME call)
- 3-minute video and architecture
- Draft Trust Card

→ 25–30 finalists + 5 waitlist

3 Grand Finale

On site · 27–28 Feb

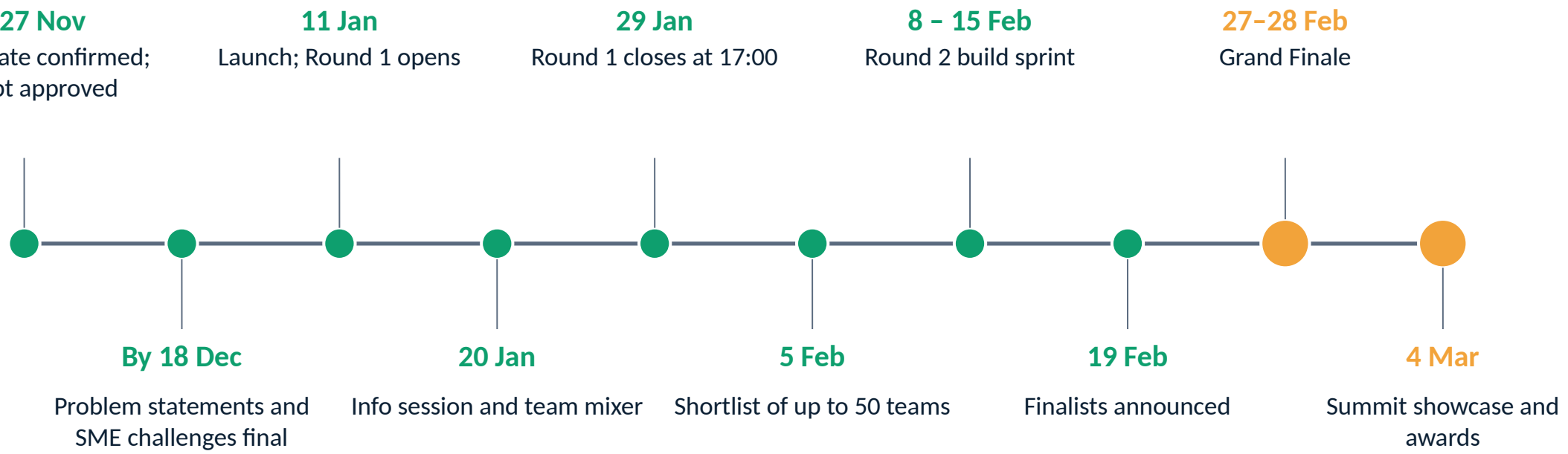
- 24-hour build from a declared baseline
- 3 mentor rounds, 2 workshops, a mini-CTF
- Panel judging, then a final for the top 6

→ Winners showcase at the summit

Plan B: a two-day format without an overnight stay if overnight use of the building is not approved.

Timeline to the summit showcase

Planned backwards from the summit, assumed to be Thursday 4 March 2027.



Avoids semester 1 exams and St Brigid's Day (Mon 1 Feb). If the summit date differs, every date moves with it and the finale stays on the weekend before.

24-hour finale run-of-show

Adapted from the reference schedule, with one hard deadline that matches the end of hacking.

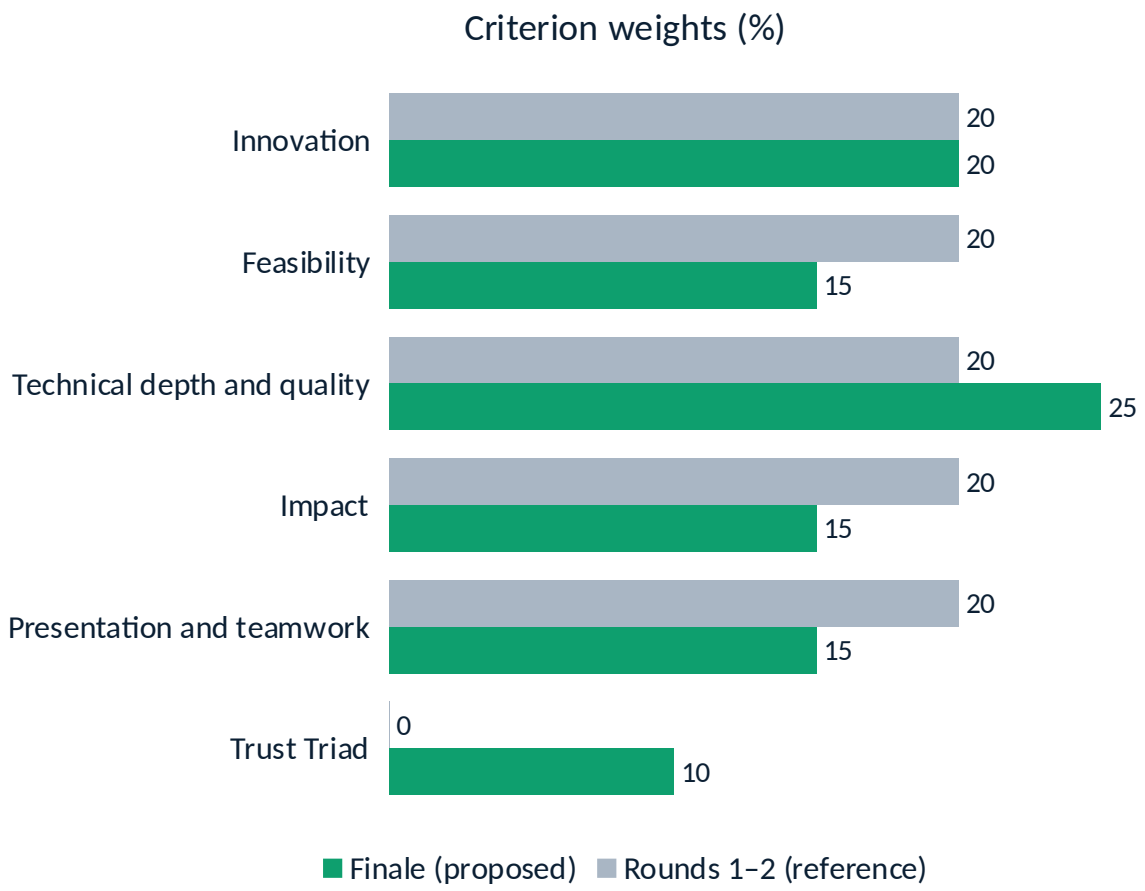
Time	Saturday 27 February
07:30	Check-in and kit collection
09:00	Opening, rules and Trust Triad
10:00	Orientation; repositories tagged
11:00	**Hacking starts (H+0)**
14:00	Workshop: securing LLM apps
15:00	Mentor round 1 · scope locked
18:00	Workshop: accessible UIs (WCAG 2.2)
21:00	Mentor round 2 · core flow working
00:00	Mini-CTF (optional, 90 minutes)

Time	Sunday 28 February
01:30	Overnight build; helpdesk and first aid
08:00	Mentor round 3 · demo rehearsal
11:00	**Code freeze and hard deadline (H+24)**
11:00	Checks and judge calibration
12:45	Panel judging: 3 panels in parallel
15:00	Expo and People's Choice vote
15:30	Final: top 6 teams
17:00	Results and closing
18:00	Close and venue handover

Meals: 13:00 lunch · 19:00 dinner · 23:30 snacks · 07:00 breakfast · 12:00 lunch. Winners present at the summit on Thursday 4 March.

Judging rewards quality and trust

Rounds 1–2 keep the reference rubric; the finale moves weight to working quality and trust.



Panels: 3 parallel panels of 3 judges; the top 2 from each go to a final panel of 5 that includes an SME owner

Calibration: judges score one sample pitch together before scoring starts

Conflicts: declared in advance; conflicted judges do not score that team

Tie-breaks: technical depth, then impact, then a vote of the final panel

Appeals: lodged within 30 minutes and decided within 60

Eight innovations we add

Each one is achievable with free or open-source tools and a volunteer team.

Trust Card

One page per team: data, AI use, top risks, accessibility, efficiency, limits.

Declared-AI policy

AI tools allowed if declared; every member can explain the code.

SME Challenge Bank

Real problems from local businesses, tagged to the 12 domains.

Summit showcase

Winners demo to SMEs at the summit, which votes an SME Choice award.

Mentored build sprint

An online Round 2 tests feasibility early and cuts no-shows.

Mini-CTF and workshops

Overnight capture-the-flag; LLM-security and WCAG sessions.

Secure event operations

MFA for organisers, capped per-team API keys, phishing alerts.

Build-on pathway

Six-week mentored sprint; links to SMEs, incubators and New Frontiers.

Rules and compliance for Ireland

Terms that suit participants, with GDPR, safeguarding and venue duties covered from day one.

For participants

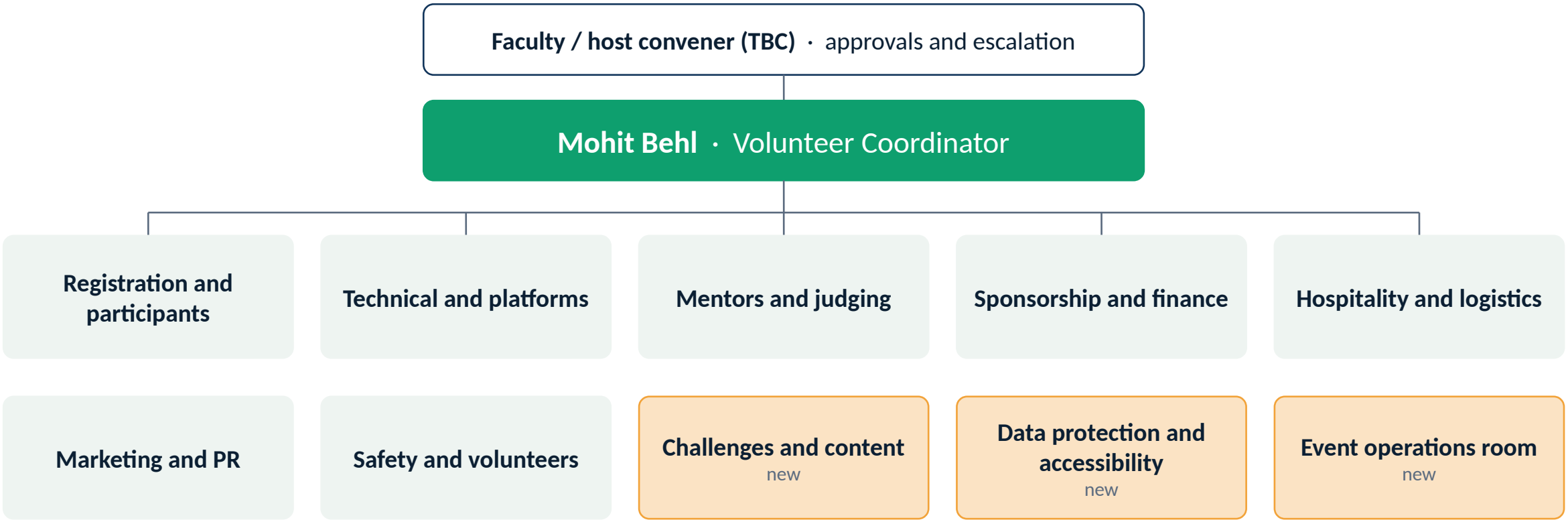
- Aged 18+ and enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland
- Teams of 2–4; teams can mix institutions
- Teams keep their IP; organisers get showcase rights
- AI allowed if declared; existing code must be declared
- Open, synthetic or consented data only
- One hard deadline and one grace policy for everyone

For organisers

- GDPR privacy notice, minimal data, deletion after 12 months
- Photo consent and a “no photos” lanyard
- Code of conduct, named contacts, women volunteers at night
- Allergen information and dietary options
- Host liability cover and approval for overnight use
- Legal or technology-transfer review of the IP terms

Ten workstreams, one volunteer coordinator

The reference event's team structure, plus new workstreams for content, data protection and operations.



Finale staffing estimate: about 16 volunteers per day shift and 7 overnight (about 35 recruited), plus about 6 for the summit-day showcase. At least two women volunteers on the overnight shift.

Budget and sponsorship framework

Free and non-profit, like the summit: an itemised budget, 10–15% contingency, mostly in-kind support.

Budget line	Main cost driver
Venue	Often in kind from the host
Catering	~185 people at peak × 6 meal points
Internet and power	Backup line, boards, UPS
A/V and streaming	Projectors, microphones, cameras
Print and merchandise	Lanyards, signage, certificates
Prizes	Agreed with sponsors
Hardware	IoT kits plus 20% spares
Security and first aid	Overnight cover
Travel bursaries (new)	Fixed fund, on application
Contingency	10–15% of the total

No amounts yet: they are set after the venue is confirmed and supplier quotes are in.

Title partner

Event title line, keynote, own challenge, final-panel seat, booth

Gold

Lightning workshop, booth, mentor team, logo on site and slides

Silver

Logo, shared booth space, mentors

Community and in-kind

Cloud credits, APIs, hardware, food, merchandise

Risks we plan for

The reference event's contingency plan, plus new risks from cloud, AI and cyber incidents.

Risk	Fallback	Source
Internet or power fails	Backup line, hotspots and UPS; extend the deadline by the outage length	Ref
Submission platform goes down	Email or shared-drive backup, checked by timestamp	Ref
Summit date not confirmed, or it changes	Shift every date by the same amount; finale stays the weekend before	New
Medical or safety incident	First aid, emergency list, incident log	Ref
Cloud or AI API outage	Recorded demo plus a code walk-through, with no penalty	New
Phishing aimed at participants	Official channels published; warnings from the operations room	New
API keys leaked	Per-team keys with spending caps; revoke and reissue	New
Personal-data incident	Host breach procedure; Data Protection Officer told at once	New
Severe weather or transport disruption	Watch Met Éireann warnings; switch to an online finale	New
Dispute over AI use or existing code	Repository tag, commit history, appeals panel	New
Winners cannot attend the weekday summit	Letters for their institutions; recorded pitch played at the showcase	New

How we will measure success

The reference event's measures, plus reach, diversity and SME engagement.

≥ 90%

Finalist attendance against confirmations

≥ 80%

Finalist teams demo a working prototype

≥ 8

Institutions represented in Round 1

≥ 30%

Women and non-binary participants

≥ 4 / 5

Average participant satisfaction

0

Serious safety or data incidents

≥ 10

SME challenges in the Challenge Bank

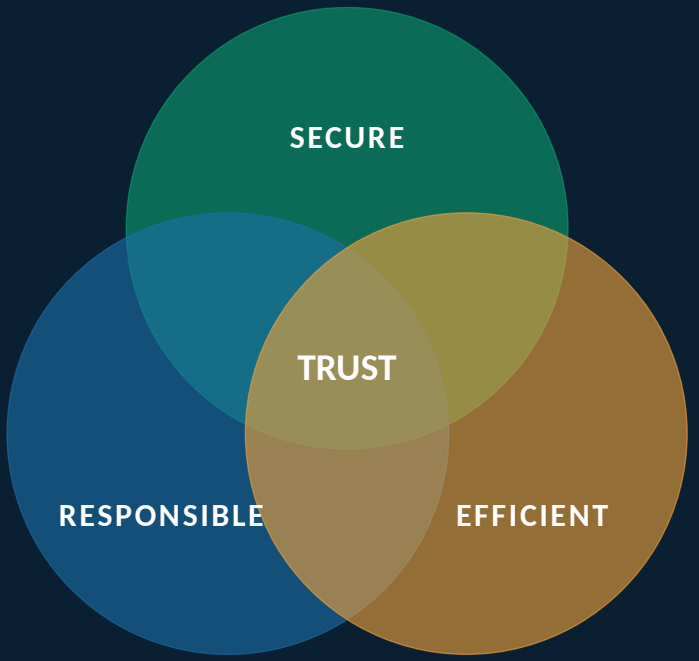
≥ 3

Teams continuing with an SME within 3 months

Proposed targets for a first edition, measured from check-in, judging, survey and repository data.

Decisions needed by 27 November

1. Confirm the summit date and agree a showcase slot with its organisers
2. Approve the concept, the three rounds and the finale weekend (or Plan B)
3. Confirm the finale venue and whether overnight use is approved
4. Approve the IP terms and the declared-AI policy, after legal review
5. Appoint the faculty convener and the 10 workstream leads
6. Approve a budget envelope and the sponsor tiers
7. Approve the 12 domains and the SME Challenge Bank



Mohit Behl
Volunteer Coordinator, IT Summit 2027